Taking Macro Shots

After you get yourself a digicam, you're bound to try close-up shots sooner or later... this is where you need to enable the macro mode.

Try to get as close as you can to the subject and use a little zoom whenever possible. Also keep the aperture size as low as possible. Using manual focus can give much more accurate results.

Exposure Metering Tricks

A digital camera detects how much light there is to calculate the best settings to get the right photo with the right amount of exposure. Cameras normally have two or three different modes of detecting the amount of light. Some cameras might detect light from the entire view; some just from a spot in the centre.

If you want to lock the exposure to another object, half-press the button to focus to that object, then move the camera to the object you want to shoot without letting go of the click—and then capture the photo.

Using Burst Mode

With scenarios like planes or fast cars, it's very difficult—almost possible—to time your shot perfectly. In such cases, use the burst mode or the continuous mode available on your camera. This will take a continuous set of images as long as you keep the button depressed.

You can choose the perfect photo from the series of images and delete the rest. Burst mode should come in especially handy while taking group photographs.

The Histogram

This is probably one of the most ignored features in a camera. It is usually accessible by pressing a button—look up your manual—and it typically appears at one corner of the LCD screen. It appears too complicated to make any sense, but the histogram is basically just an overview of the image you're looking at. It gives a general idea of the intensity of the different colour tones in the current view.

Generally, a well-balanced image with not too many bright or too many dark spots will display on the histogram without any major spikes or drops but as a fairly even graph.

A flat graph with a sudden spike may mean a photo with lots of dark regions and a small area of very high brightness levels.

Camera Care

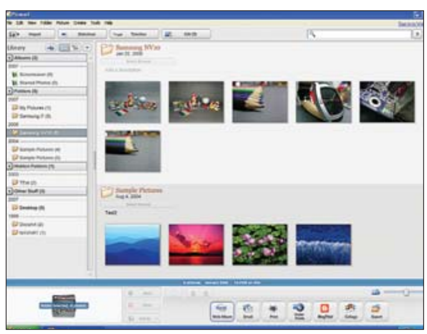
Cameras, no matter what size and shape, are all still pretty delicate devices that need to be handled with care. Here are some useful handling tips.

- Avoid taking your camera exposed in dusty and sandy locations such as beaches. A sand particle can easily lodge itself into one of the many crevices. If this happens, try using a toothbrush gently to dislodge the particles. Do not use the brush on the lens.
- The lenses on most cameras are tiny, and fingerprints or specks of dust get magnified, which means you get a generally smudgy image. Use an air blower or a soft cloth to clean your lens—only if it appears dirty.

Going Online—And Photo Management

Once you own a digital camera, it won't take too long before you have loads of photos piling up on your hard drive. It's a good idea to install photo management software such as Picasa (**http://picasa.google.com**). Once installed, Picasa will scan your drive for photos. Picasa allows you to set comments for your albums. It sorts photos by folders and by month and day. Picasa even allows you to tweak some basic parameters like colour, brightness, and contrast.

Google has a photo hosting site called PicasaWeb (**http://picasaweb.google.com**) which works well with the Picasa software. Uploading photos to your PicasaWeb account takes just a few clicks.

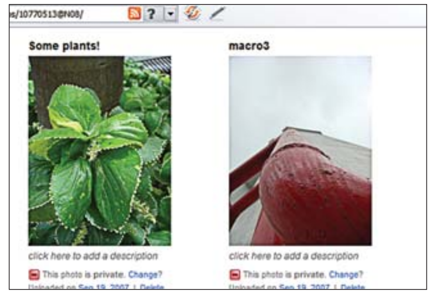


Using Picasa2 to manage photos

Another software that has been making the waves of late is Adobe's Lightroom. It, unlike Google's Picasa, isn't free, but is still a very good photo management and manipulation tool.

Online Photography Communities

One of the most interesting things you could do once you have a digital camera is to join online photography communities. Flickr (www.flickr.com) is probably the most well-known and widely-used. Flickr, now owned by Yahoo!, not only allows you to upload photos, but even join groups of other photographers with similar interests. People can easily search for photos and post comments on them. Use such communities and other photo hosting sites to host photos and then link them to your blog or your personal site. Mail your Flickr album links to your friends and relatives—distributing photos has never been this easy. You can do the same with your videos by registering for a YouTube account, for example.



Save your photographs online to share and back them up

Some General Tips

Here are some general camera tips:

- Avoid taking photos of people from a completely different height. Come down to the level of the subject.
- Whenever using tripods isn't possible, try and use support from a chair or a table while clicking photos. Blurring of images due to longer exposures can be avoided.
- Experiment by taking some vertical photos—some photos are best represented in a vertical layout. Photos taken diagonally can give a unique look.
- Most cameras come with different colour modes such as Black and White and Sepia tone. Try these to give a classic look to your photos. Another thing to try is different white balance settings in different environments.
- Depth of field is a very important part of good photos. Try and use larger aperture sizes to get more depth of field in photos. (We can't go into detail here in terms of depth of field.)
- Avoid taking photos facing a light. Preferably, try and take shots with the light falling on the subject.
- In places where there is abundance of light, use the least possible ISO, the largest F-Number (smallest aperture), and the fastest shutter speed to get the clearest of photos. In case of very low light, select the largest ISO sensitivity and the smallest F-Number, but keep the shutter speed moderately high to avoid motion blurring.

At the end of the day, no rule-book can make you good at photography; creativity, patience, experimentation, and originality will. ⊠